

ALTAI

Star: Blue Giant

Known for: Alabaster Council, The Corsairs of Altai, The Dome City Khorsabad, The Dark Sector

Exports: J-Drive technology, aluminium, rare minerals

Imports: Medicine, spices, wine, knowledge,

The inhospitable Altai system was nothing more than a corsair ruled gateway to The Quadrant of the Pillar just a few decades ago. Now it is the Firstcome center of the Third Horizon.

THE CORSAIR STAR

The Altai system has always been considered the wealthiest and most populous in the Quadrant, even if it has stagnated dramatically on both counts during the last two hundred cycles before the fall of Coriolis.

Today, the system is home to the Draconites, the Nomads and many more, that left the Kua system after the Second Portal War. The Coriolis Council, that once rules the Horizon, has been replaced by the Alabaster Council of Khorsabad on Marakanda.

HISTORY OF ALTAI

The few surviving sources that recount the history of Marakanda describe the dwarf planet as one of the first colonies in the Third Horizon. The settlers made this small chunk of space rock into their new home, and built Marakanda's wealth on trade with Mira and the then-prosperous Odacon, as well as Algol and Dabaran. The trade hub that emerged in Marakanda allowed the system to flourish and thrive.

In Altai's early history, a long and grievous civil war known as the Epkyros set the system aflame and sundered the Quadrant of the Pillar to its very core. But from its ashes rose the kingdom of Marakanda. During this time of recovery and prosperity, Marakanda would blossom into a symbol of a new age in the Quadrant of the Pillar. The Altai system was quickly put in order and the servants of the rajahs were ready to bring the light of civilization to the rest of the Quadrant.

Sadly, this prosperous age was short lived, and once again the Dark between the Stars lit up with thermonuclear destruction. The spark that set the kingdom aflame was the discovery of ruins below Marakanda, which implied the city-state had been built on remnants of even older settlements. A heated debate ensued among historians, rhapsodes, and the general populace – arousing tempers and creating bad blood all the way up the social ladder to the ruling raj family, Kushtriya. The rajahs went to war to defend their right and honour. This second civil war raged for several cycles and weakened not only the ruling Kushtriya dynasty, but also the entire Altai system.

After cycles of war, the interloping war lord Tang Gol broke through the outward defenses of the system and ended the conflict with two swift strikes against the warring parties. Tang Gol – now an old man – became the new ruler of Altai, and appropriated the ways of the previous rulers. He levied high tariffs on those who wished to use his portals. Those with sufficient firepower were given dispensation to traverse both the system and the portals without taxation or interference.

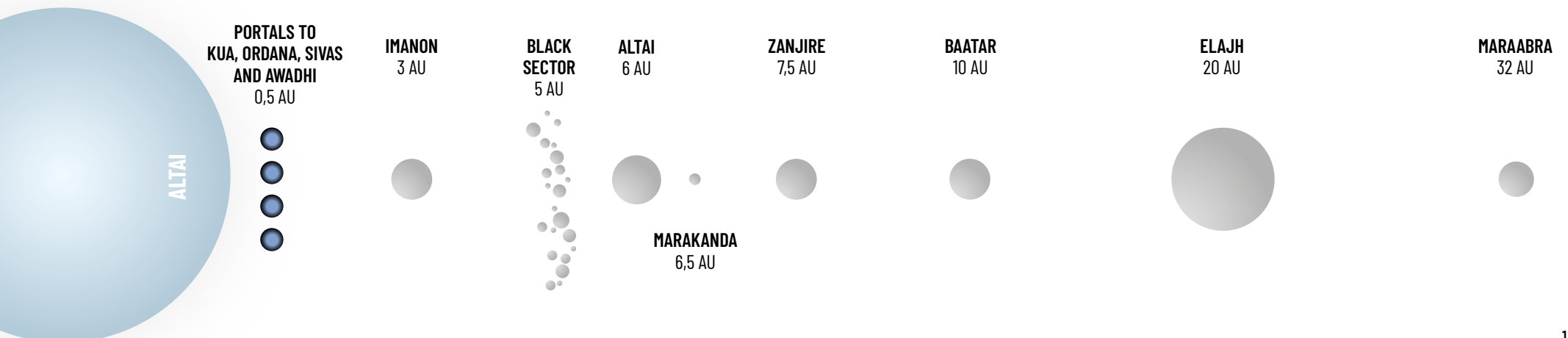
BIRTH OF KHORSABAD

Shortly after taking control of the system, Tang Gol passed away at age 122. In an act that would later be called Na'gandas Dark Segment, Tang Gol's generals resolved the issue of succession rights by murdering his descendants. Next they focused on the subsequent problem: each other. Following a number of smaller skirmishes, they agreed to put an end to their hostilities in order to create a new, unified republic.

This so-called "republic of the khors" sought to bury the past – starting with the raj's most powerful symbol: the city-state of Marakanda. The republic gave the city a new name, "Khorsabad" and encouraged its use among outsiders – and, later, the city's residents. The kingdom's former colonies were split between the republic's new rulers, and reformed to become the property of the rulers themselves – assets to be passed down the generations to their descendants.

ALTAI TODAY

Many generations later, Altai lost much of its former greatness. The fragments that remained were worn down. Until the Second Portal War. With the near destruction of Kua and much of the Horizon in flames, Altai blossomed. The Nomads of Zhau together with the Draconites rebuilt Khorsabad, brought back prosperity and influence. And established a new Council of the Horizon, a political and cultural stage where each faction and system can participate in debates and decisions.



SYSTEM OVERVIEW

Imanon: Home planet of the Magnesium Sultans.

Black Sector: Asteroid belt containing many old defence systems.

Altai: Primarily known for its 27 moons.

Marakanda: Home of the Alabaster Council and the city of Khorsabad.

Zanjire: Former slave colony, now an agricultural world.

Baatar: Mining planet beset by waring vizirs and warlords.

Elajh: Gas giant with mining colonies run by the Gas Emirs.

Maraabrah: Forgotten ice planet where the lost fleet of the corsairs is rumoured to rest.

THE ALABASTER COUNCIL

The Alabaster Council is a united political congregation. Each of the major faction has a council member, just like the Coriolis Council had in the old days. But this time, the seats are fairly distributed, with neither the Zenithians nor the Firstcome having the upper hand. Even non-humans and minor factions have a seat now.

Current council members:

- **Free League:** Tojan Kuma
- **Mystics:** Tarek al-Farhat
- **Humanites:** Phyllias
- **Church of the Icons:** Jorin Afta
- **Draconites:** Sahdi bat-Erden
- **Nomad Federation:** Janhagir
- **Consortium:** Sandrol Paar
- **Legion:** Sahumia Taslim
- **Zenithian Hegemony:** Olandria Quassar

All Council members have the right to raise one issue per meeting, which the Council must then take a stand on. The real statecraft occurs under the lotus; in the city's tea houses and the bath houses, during banquets, or in darkend conference rooms.

THE CORSAIRS

A group of corsairs, that operated in (and quasi ruled) Altai for the longest time, still play an important role in the Quadrant. They are political pawns, selfish soldiers of fortune, but are also economic powerhouses that serve as traders and lines of communication.

The Alabaster Council declared most of the letters of marquis issued by the old rulers of Altai invalid. Many pirates moved to other systems, but some still linger in the Altai system, waiting for the right moment to strike.

LOCATIONS IN THE ALTAI SYSTEM

The Altai system is famous for its immense asteroid belt. But it also contains other wonders. The gas giant Elajh is home to the Gas Emirs. Meanwhile, the ice-covered Maraabrah is known for its large deposits of aluminium – a resource the Consortium covets, but has difficulty reaching due to the planet's location beyond the Black Sector.

IMANON

Imanon, the planet closest to the system's star, has been called the Janus Face of Altai. Its orbit is transfixed so that one side constantly points towards the star while the other faces the void. This has turned one side of the planet into an inhospitable surface on which a variety of molten metals flows. The other side is a frozen wasteland of rock covered in enormous craters and canyons. Toxic gases make the planet's atmosphere unbreathable.

The planet has a single permanent settlement. Most people on the planet inhabit one of the many mobile mining facilities on the surface. Many are bound by slave contracts, but this is changing due to the slave revolts on Zanjire. A Consortium-supported affiliate, the Altai Cartel, is establishing a presence on the planet's dark hemisphere. But its progress is slow as a number of politically motivated murders haunt the organization. The Magnesium Sultans are another political actor on the planet. They live in powerful crawlers that journey deep into the canyons of the planet's dark hemisphere. As Imanon is located close to the portal fields and is inside the Black Sector, it is one of the system's more accessible locations for Zenithians to reach and exploit.

THE BLACK SECTOR

Altai's military proficiency relies on an ancient security system that was created by the first colonists during the cataclysmic First Portal War. The security system is located in the gigantic asteroid cloud that resides between the portal fields and the majority of the system. Torpedo chambers were secretly built in the belt's rocks. These were filled with both troops in stasis and devastating automatic missile systems.

This defence network is known as the Black Sector (sometimes called "The Black" for short). There are two known routes through it: the Yamuna Trail and the Tang Gol-path. The Black Sector is controlled by Draconites. How the defense network is maintained remains an enigma to this day.

ALTAI

The planet which gives the Altai system its name is a colossal chunk of rock surrounded by 27 moons. The best-known settlement is on Altai 11 with its surface covered in greenhouses and orbit full of sunlight capturing mirrors. Altai 11 is key to feeding the inhabitants of the system since the revolution on Zanjire 12 years ago.

Another famous location is the moon Altai-17 where the famed courtesans – the Sirens of Achelos – conduct a carnal sacrament to honour the Faceless One.

Besides this, mining operations have developed on the planet and its moons.

ZANJIRE

This planet was once a slave colony. Massive farms run by slave merchant families and relying on indentured labor produced such high crop yields that Zanjire was known as the breadbasket of the entire Altai system. But the slaves revolted in a large-scale uprising. These insurrectionists formed the confederation of new Zanjire and pressured the families – once the rulers of the planet – to hand over all they owned. Since then it has become home to a broad spectrum of people trying to realize their dreams and aspirations. Zanjire stills plays a role in food production, but the farms are far less productive now and a big part of the harvest stays on the planet.

BAATAR

Baatar has a highly successful mining economy and is considered the jewel in the crown of Marakanda.

MARAKANDA

Diameter: 3.765 km (30% of Kua)

Gravity: 0.5 Standard gravity

Day length: 32 hours

Rotation period: 381 days

Axial tilt: 43 degrees

In the far reaches of the Qui-cluster outside the Black Sector, Marakanda slowly traverses its orbit. This dwarf planet, whose rocky surface gleams in turquoise in the darkness of space, is home to one of the most infamous places of the Quadrant: the legendary Khorsabad.

KHORSABAD

Consisting of a vast collection of emerald green domes and endless towers, Khorsabad appears to clamber across the planet's rocky surface. While the air is thin and many visitors wear an oxygen mask just to be on the safe side, the streets are permanently filled with people.

The city's grandest and most beautiful dome is the gigantic Dome of Kacche – an artefact of those who first settled the planet. These pioneers forged and constructed the green dome before the devastating Epkyros. Despite its age, the excellence of its construction is to this day unrivalled anywhere in the Horizon. Khorsabad has developed in stages and a plethora of cultures has imparted on the city a fascinating architectural design and tone.

The city has about 2.3 million residents, with an additional 700.000 visitors.

THE BAZAAR DISTRICT

The Bazaar District is the heart of Khorsabad. The system's raiding economy has turned this district into a cornucopia – filled with merchandise of every description, originating both from within the Quadrant and from across the Third Horizon. Goods are traded at all hours in the Bazaar District. The buyers and sellers may change, but the commerce itself never stops. All goods sold here are contraband in some form or another – a situation that surprises nobody.

The bazaar provides delights for all of a visitor's senses – but none more so than the senses of smell and taste. Here, spices, food, oils, and incenses offer relief from the sometimes unpleasant odors that characterize the rest of the crowded city. Meantime, mouths water and tongues tingle at the variety of exotic fruit, fresh meals prepared to order, and refreshing hot or cold beverages – all reflecting the city's fusion of cultures. From the market's many food stalls to long-established restaurants, the bazaar is a gastronome's delight.

Despite the tremendous variety of goods and services that are traded here and the impressive amount of birr that changes hands each day, the Bazaar District is surprisingly serene. This is due to the fact that the merchants themselves govern the bazaar through negotiated consensus.

The Bazaar District is divided into stalls or sections in which merchants display their wares. The spice traders are grouped together in one area, the porcelain mongers in another, the

slavers in a third, and so on. Of course there are merchants who offer a broad selection of wares, but the specialist traders disapprove of these “mediocre generalists” and to appease a majority of the merchants these traders have been consigned to the outskirts. While merchants frequently disagree about how the bazaar should be run, all agree that consensus is better than having rules imposed by an outside authority. All also agree that thieves have no place in the bazaar and those caught stealing are typically tried, convicted and shot on sight.

Notable NPCs

- **Yasmina al-Khar:** Spice Matriarch. Calm, terrifying, and absolutely incorruptible once consensus is reached.
- **Brek One-Hand:** Former corsair turned information broker. Knows who owes whom.

THE EMERALD TEAR

The Emerald Tear – also known as the Green Gaze – is the entertainment district in Khorsabad. Located between the spaceport and the bazaar, the district received its name after construction work to expand the city's water reserves caused a powerful earthquake. During the quake, large chunks of the green dome of Kacche crashed onto the buildings below. Before salvage crews could remove the pieces, they mysteriously fused with the cityscape. The incident has given the district's buildings a curious appearance, characterized by large, dull shimmering crystals.

The crystals did not concern the district's inhabitants for long. The district exists to sell temporary bliss and there is no time for brooding thoughts. Instead, the district does its best to live up to the exotic name it acquired – determined to satisfy all comers with the most exotic desires and vices to be found anywhere in the Horizon. Visitors to Khorsabad join the city's permanent residents in the Emerald Tear to gamble, drink, and dance until all their birr has slipped from their fingers.

Notable NPCs

- **Lyris Greenveil:** Proprietor of a crystal-infused pleasure house. Rumored to hear voices from the fused dome shards.
- **Kalo Den:** Fixer for gamblers and performers. Smiles when people lose everything.

YAL-HARRA

Yal-Harra – the Temple District – is dedicated to prayer and contemplation. The district is one of the few parts of the Raj kingdom that is still preserved in its original form. Yal-Harra has

been skillfully preserved by its guardians. According to legend, the warlord Tang Gol proclaimed on his deathbed that Marakanda stands and falls with its virtue to the Icons.

Tang Gol was considered a devout Icon worshipper who revered many different doctrines, and this is reflected in the variety of worship found in this district. The warlord's own temple, built by his successors, is a magnificent monument that outshines many of the other ancestral shrines that can be found in the area.

Notable NPCs

- **High Custodian Rameh:** Guardian of Tang Gol's temple. Preaches unity, practices leverage.
- **Sister Veyra:** Mystic preacher whose sermons may cause riots or miracles, depending on the day.

THE SPACEPORT

The constant activity at the Khorsabad spaceport makes it one of the city's most important places. If the bazaar is the city's heart, then the spaceport is its lungs. The port is a hive of activity, and its transit halls and docks are always filled with people or goods awaiting transport to new destinations. The loading of ships, customs processing, ship repairs, and the passage of numerous groups of pilgrims are some of the sights that can be seen in this district.

Notable NPCs

- **Dockmaster Huun Sar:** Appears incompetent. Is not.
- **Pilgrim-Captain Sadaf:** Leads massive Icon pilgrimages and controls their schedules like a general.

THE REMEMBRANCE PLAZA

The most elegant area of Khorsabad is found in the innermost core. Here the streets are wide and spotless, the air is easier to breathe, and the ever-present noise that permeates elsewhere in the city is absent. At the center is the Remembrance Plaza. The plaza functions as a gigantic monument to the Ghaziz – the warriors who fought and died under Tang Gol when he conquered the rajahs in two famous battles, at the moons of Altai and Baatar.

Notable NPCs

- **Captain Arjun Vahl:** Alabaster Guard officer. Loyal to the city, not the Council.

THE ETERNAL GARDEN

The Eternal Garden is one of the most beautiful places in all of Khorsabad. The Alabaster Council has invested enormous amounts of time and birr to create this exquisite garden, the design of

which is inspired by all the corners of the Quadrant, but also the Horizon at large. This area is a remnant of the Marakanda of old. In the centre of the Eternal Garden we find the Alabaster Hall, where men and women in ancient times, with the aid of the public, ruled the Raj kingdom of Marakanda. And now the home of the Alabaster Council.

Notable NPCs

- **Council Aide Ilyas Noor:** Knows every secret vote and half the bribes.

THE ALABASTER HALL

Made from delicately carved white stone, Alabaster Hall stands as a mighty expression of the collected authority of Altai. Columns, statues, and sculptures of mythical beasts and ancestors decorate the magnificent hall's facade, which is polished and maintained regularly. If visitors are bedazzled by the exterior, then the interior will leave them completely in awe. Inside, one experiences the very best of Marakandan art. Mosaics, statues, and the constant shimmer of alabaster in all its forms and nuances meld together and make the room come almost alive.

Altai's elite gather here almost every day – although it must be noted that there are often empty seats. At the end of each segment, the full Council gathers to fill the hall and discuss the most important issues – both internal and external – that face the republic. Council members and their assistants who stray from attending these meetings soon face the contempt of their peers and risk being expelled from the Council.

THE BATHHOUSES

The bathhouses serve as important locations for those who live in Khorsabad. Many kinds of baths exist and the bathing culture has become an integral part of the daily routine for many citizens. It is well known that, besides the Supradome, it is the baths that act as a key venue for business and political negotiations in the city.

THE SUPRADOME

In the District of the Fighting Lions, all manner of competitions and contests are concentrated. The greatest venue here is the Supradome – an enormous arena that's host to almost all top sporting events and physical trials. As with much else about life in Khorsabad, the city's sports and games reflect its multicultural heritage. The Supradome has become a focal point throughout the Quadrant of the Pillar for sports and other events. Each week, the Supradome hosts chaotic but wildly popular scooter races. These races are an imported sport – originating on the distant planet

Nharmanda – but it is here in Khorsabad that they have flourished. In the Supradome, contestants race their low-flying grav-vehicles at breakneck velocity. The reckless tempo of the scooter races usually results in a high number of casualties.

THE WRESTLING COLLEGES

Wrestling has become another popular sport in Altai. Many wrestlers train from a young age, and competitors gather in Khorsabad from all corners of the Third Horizon. The most popular style is a Zero-g variety. Known as Hai-wrestling, it takes many forms. These include one-on-one competitions, teams contests, and a variant in which the goal is to defend a point in the match ring. There are several wrestling colleges in Altai. Most are concentrated in Khorsabad, but notable schools exist across the system.

Notable NPCs

- **Master Hai-Kora:** Zero-g wrestling trainer. Fanatical about honor, secretly drowning in debt.

THE CLIFF CITY

The district known as the Cliff City is home to most of the clerks and officials of Khorsabad. These bureaucrats have the important role of carrying out the will of the Alabaster Council in the city. This district is also home to the headquarters of the Alabaster Guard, as well as the offices and official residences for diplomatic envoys from across the Third Horizon. It's in no way grandiose but is still a home away from home for people from all levels of the Consortium, including some mid-ranking Zenithians who act as the Consortium's mouthpiece.

Notable NPCs

- **Envoy Kessan Tor:** Consortium representative who lives too modestly to be honest.

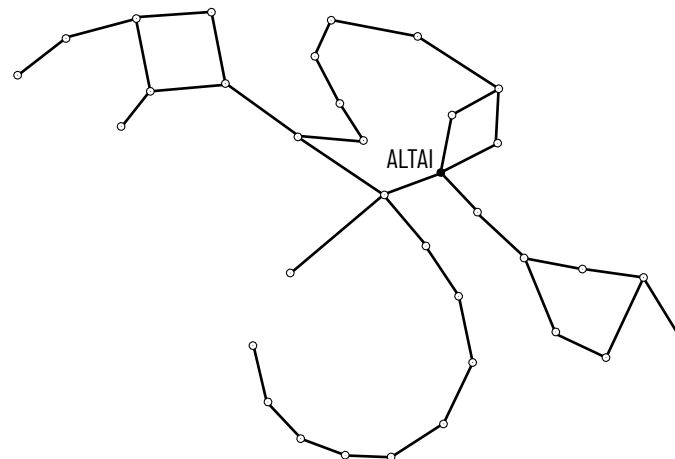
THE GATEWAY TO THE QUADRANT

It is said that Khorsabad is the gateway to the Quadrant of the Pillar and its entire culture, which is not far from the truth. Many of the Quadrant's inhabitants have made their mark on the city in the form of the arts, cuisine, and doctrines of faith.

The Quadrant's citizens are open in nature and have historically been very welcoming of their neighbors. However, they do not like Zenithians very much – even after the founding of the Alabaster Council. Many are not happy about the Zenithian expansion within the Quadrant. The truth is, Zenithian customs and traditions often seem bizarre to the common person in the Quadrant of the Pillar.

CITY TRUTHS (WHAT EVERYONE KNOWS)

- The green shimmer of the domes affects mood, sleep, and superstition.
- Real power is negotiated in tea houses, bathhouses, and banquets—not in Council sessions.
- Everything in the Bazaar is illegal somewhere.
- The Black Sector keeps Altai safe... and terrified.
- Outsiders are welcome, but never trusted.



KHORSABAD

